POLITICAL THEORY: AN INTRODUCTION

Roots of Political Theory

- **Reason** -humans reflect on their actions; **Language** -humans express ideas & debate what is good/desirable.
- Political theory = systematic study of values (freedom, equality, justice) that guide political life.
- Checks whether institutions (govt., schools, and offices) actually deliver these values; suggests reform.

What Is Politics?

- **Popular views:** public service (politicians) / manipulation & scams (public) / "dirty politics".
- Gandhi: politics is like coils of a snake -must be engaged with, not avoided.
- No society survives without collective decision-making → institutions (family, tribe, economy, and govt.).
- Govt. decisions (economic, foreign, education policy) affect everyone → people organise, protest, and negotiate.
- **Definition:** Politics = negotiation among people to shape collective decisions & resolve common problems -not just what politicians do.

What Do We Study in Political Theory?

- Values like democracy, freedom, equality are enshrined in constitutions -built on centuries of debate.
- Concepts (freedom, equality, justice) have many definitions -unlike maths (one definition of a triangle) -because they concern human relationships & opinions, not fixed objects.

Equality -A Working Example

- Queue-jumping → we expect equal opportunity for all.
- Special counters for elderly/disabled → special treatment can be justified.
- Poverty stops people reaching shop/hospital/school → equal opportunity alone isn't enough; need fair distribution of resources.

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- Conclusion: Equality = equal opportunity + special protection for the vulnerable + fair distribution, backed by a responsible agency.

The Socratic Method (Plato's Republic)

- Socrates: 'wisest man' of Athens; questioned popular beliefs; condemned to death for it.
- Dialogue with Cephalus asks: 'What is justice?'
- Def. 1 -truth-telling + repaying debts → fails (returning a weapon to a madman).
- Def. 2 -good to friends, harm to enemies' → fails (harming anyone only makes them worse, never just).
- **Method:** use reason to expose inconsistencies in a view until it collapses -the core technique of political theory.

Why Study Political Theory?

- **Professional relevance:** like basic maths, useful for many future careers.
- **Responsible citizenship:** needed to vote & participate (gram sabhas, online debate) meaningfully.
- **Everyday relevance:** freedom/equality/secularism show up daily -caste, gender, class bias.
- **Reasoned debate:** trains us to defend opinions with logic, not just assertion.

"Man is by nature a political animal."

-: Aristotle

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